INTRODUCTION:
SOMETHING ABOUT MYSELF



Arab coasting dhows off the Malabar coast. A watercolour painted by Lieutenant-Fireworker Thomas Cussans in 1820.

He stood up against the mast, swinging in circles, swooping from sky to sea, and looking out under his hand. The rising sun climbed slowly out of the trough of the waves astern. Ahead the sea stretched to a low dark line which might be the land. From horizon to horizon, covering all that sea, the white horses rode westward towards the doubtful coast.

Jason saw the land harden before his eyes as the ship rose on a great wave. He shouted, ‘Land ho!’, and then: ‘Coromandel!’

John Masters, *Coromandel!*, 1955